

Long-Term Tolerability and Patient-Reported Outcomes With Cosmetic Versus Prescription Acne Therapy

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ABSTRACT

Secondary analysis examined tolerability and quality-of-life endpoints from the 12-week acne treatment comparison. Skin irritation symptoms were mild to absent in the cosmetic regimen group across all assessment windows, whereas prescription therapy produced higher irritation scores peaking at week 4. Facial skin hydration, assessed via transepidermal water loss measurements, showed greater preservation with cosmetic treatment. Post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation improved more favorably in those with baseline darker skin types receiving cosmetic therapy. Patient-reported confidence in appearance and social comfort improved significantly more in the cosmetic group. Among patients completing the full 12-week course, 96.8% in the cosmetic arm versus 82.6% in the prescription arm reported willingness to continue their assigned regimen. Subset analysis in darker skin types (Fitzpatrick IV-VI) revealed superior tolerability with cosmetic therapy while maintaining comparable efficacy. These findings suggest the cosmetic regimen may offer particular advantage in diverse populations with sensitivity concerns.

Trial Context

Underlying double-blind randomized active-control trial comparing prescription retinoid-peroxide combination (adapalene 0.1%/benzoyl peroxide 2.5%) with over-the-counter salicylic acid regimen (1% cleanser, 2% lotion).